Commas

Three rules – and where German is different

REMEMBER

German: a comma around every subordinate clause. **English:** commas in only three places – **before** the main clause, **around** extra information, **between** two main clauses.

The three rules

1 BEFORE	Something comes **before** the main clause → **comma** after it. an introductory word, phrase or *when/if/because* clause (after very short phrases the comma is optional)	*However, the camps are expensive.* *In the article, the author argues …* *When they return home, old habits come back.*
2 AROUND	**Extra information** in the sentence → **commas around** it. Test: you could put it in brackets.	*Ben Huang, who works in Seattle, moved back.* *Rachel Hughes, a journalist, argues …* *Critics, however, remain sceptical.*
3 BETWEEN	Two main clauses joined by **but, so, or** → **comma** before the linking word. also between the items of a list – but usually no comma before *and*	*The town is small, but it has fast internet.* *parents, teachers and psychologists*

NEVER: A COMMA ALONE BETWEEN TWO MAIN CLAUSES

× *The camps are popular, they are expensive.*

× *The camps are popular, however, they are expensive.*

✓ *The camps are popular. However, they are expensive.*

✓ *The camps are popular; however, they are expensive.*

✓ *The camps are popular, but they are expensive.*

German speakers, watch out!

In German, every subordinate clause gets a comma. In English, a subordinate clause after the main clause usually gets **none** – unless it is extra information (rule 2) or a contrast (*whereas, although*):

NO COMMA BEFORE …	EXAMPLE
that (German: „…, dass“)	*The author claims that young people are moving back.*
to + infinitive (German: „…, um zu“)	*Many teenagers go to camps to get a break.*
what, why, how, whether / if (= ob)	*It is unclear whether the camps really help.*
because, if (= wenn)**, when, until …** after the main clause	*Teenagers book places because they want a break.*
who, which, that with **necessary** information	*People who live in cities pay high rents.*
than (German: „…, als“)	*Living there is cheaper than many people think.*

Model paragraph

THE THREE RULES IN A TEXT

In her article,1 Rachel Hughes,2 a journalist,2 argues ø that digital detox camps are becoming increasingly popular. According to the author,1 many parents ø who worry about their children's well-being ø book a place. Teenagers,2 however,2 also sign up on their own ø because they want a break from being available all the time. When they return home,1 old habits often come back,3 so critics doubt ø that the camps have a lasting effect.

1 2 3 = comma, with its rule ø = comma in German, none in English

ALSO

Numbers: *1,500 people · 2.5 per cent* (German: 1.500 · 2,5) Direct speech: *She says, "…"* (German: Sie sagt: „…“) Letters: *Dear Sarah,*

Practice: add the missing punctuation (or none)

1. Many experts believe that the trend will continue.
2. According to a recent study young people are moving back to small towns.
3. Millbrook which has only a few thousand inhabitants now has fast internet.
4. Teenagers who spend hours online often feel stressed.
5. When the teenagers come back old habits return.
6. The camps are popular however they are very expensive.
7. Some parents feel guilty because they work long hours.
8. The mayor is optimistic about the future of the town but many critics are less sure.

→ Solution on the next page.

Solution

Punctuation in **colour**.

1	Many experts believe that the trend will continue.	ø no comma before *that*
2	According to a recent study**,** young people are moving back to small towns.	1 comma after an introductory phrase
3	Millbrook**,** which has only a few thousand inhabitants**,** now has fast internet.	2 extra information about Millbrook
4	Teenagers who spend hours online often feel stressed.	ø necessary information: which teenagers?
5	When the teenagers come back**,** old habits return.	1 *when* clause before the main clause
6	The camps are popular**.** However**,** they are very expensive. *or* … popular**;** however**,** …	! never a comma alone between two main clauses
7	Some parents feel guilty because they work long hours.	ø *because* after the main clause
8	The mayor is optimistic about the future of the town**,** but many critics are less sure.	3 two main clauses joined by *but*